9.9. Physical activity

Exercise is defined as any movement that makes the muscles work and requires the body to burn calories. There are many types of physical activity, including swimming, running, jogging, walking and dancing, to name a few.Being active has been shown to have many health benefits, both physically and mentally.



Fig 9.4: Physical activity

9.9.1 Types of Physical Activity

The four main types of physical activity are aerobic, muscle-strengthening, bone-strengthening, and stretching. Aerobic activity is the type that benefits your heart and lungs the most.

a) Aerobic Activity

Aerobic activity moves the large muscles, such as those in the arms and legs. Running, swimming, walking, bicycling, dancing, and doing jumping jacks are examples of aerobic activity. Aerobic activity is also called endurance activity. Aerobic activity makes the heart beat faster than usual and makes the person to breathe harder during this type of activity. Over time, regular aerobic activity makes the heart and lungs stronger and able to work better.

b) Other Types of Physical Activity

The other types of physical activity like muscle-strengthening, bone strengthening and stretching benefit the body in other ways.

Muscle-strengthening activities improve the strength, power, and endurance of the muscles. Doing pushups and sit-ups, lifting weights, climbing stairs, and working in the garden are examples of muscle-strengthening activities.

With bone-strengthening activities feet, legs, or arms support the body weight, and the muscles push against the bones. This helps make the bone stronger. Running, walking, jumping rope and lifting weights are examples of bone-strengthening activities.

Muscle-strengthening and bonestrengthening activities also can be aerobic, depending on whether they make the heart and lungs work harder than usual. For example, running is both an aerobic activity and a bone-strengthening activity.

Stretching helps improve flexibility and ability to fully move the joints. Touching toes, doing side stretches, and doing yoga exercises are examples of stretching.

9.9.2. Benefits of physical activity

1) Assists in weight control mainly by burning calories and thereby reducing body fat.
2) Raises self-esteem and physical awareness.
3) Reduces symptoms of ageing.
4) Allows body to use fats and sugars more efficiently.
5) Improves digestion and metabolism
6) Strengthens and improves the functioning of the heart and lungs.

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